



As easy as pie

Tired of all the run-of-the-mill configurations? Here's how you can piece together the right components and build a PC that suits your style

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With prices of components fast falling in the computer industry, this is certainly a good time to either upgrade your PC or buy a fully-loaded branded machine. But if the textbook configurations offered don't excite you, and if tinkering with hardware is in your blood, you could build one for yourself exactly the way you like it.

But before you bring out the screwdriver and get elbow-deep into putting your dream machine together, here are a few things that you should consider.

If you buy a branded PC, you are shielded from some of the hassles and risks, at least for a year or so by the after sales service and repair support that companies provide. But if you prefer the do-it-yourself way and problems crop up after you have assembled your machine, the only person you can bank on for troubleshooting is yourself. You will have to go around hunting to find a replacement for the damaged component

and you'll have to fix all the bugs yourself. Take the plunge only if you are confident that you can handle any hassles that crop up after you've built your dream machine.

The nuts and bolts

You should possess a good understanding of the market, only then will you be able to acquire the right components at the right prices. The market right now is vibrant with prices changing almost every week. Therefore, to get a fair idea of a component's price and reliability, check it out with different dealers. Don't ever walk out and buy components on a whim. Spend a reasonable amount of time doing some research on the products that you intend to buy.

You can buy components either from a retailer or from the grey market. If you decide to buy from a retailer, chances are that the components will be priced higher than in smaller outlets or in the grey market, because here you are provided with a warranty. Your next choice is that